Existentialism and the Authentic Life

- Despite his pain from migraines, seizures, and lack of fame during his lifetime (many of his books sold less than 1000 copies despite being celebrated posthumously), Nietzsche embraced the idea of the eternal recurrence and Amor fati.
- Nietzsche was loath to point out examples of the Ubermensch, since one shouldn't base their life on that of another but create their own unique existence. However the term is considered applicable to Julius Caesar, Alexander the Great, Homer, and Goethe, so it applies to both military and poetic genius. The Ubermensch stretches to overcome themselves and become a better person, like the tightrope walker actively seeking to not fall into the abyss. Nietzsche thought directing the Will to rise to challenges an integral part of becoming, and a friend or lover that tries to remove hindrances does a disservice.
- Nietzsche found great value in friendship. Good friends inspire each other towards the ideal and have the courage to challenge each other if one is going astray.
- Heidegger and Ortega were both phenomenologists that liked to make up words. Heidegger is notoriously difficult but his ideas influenced later existentialists. The idea of phenomenology is that philosophers study phenomena, and Heidegger in particular asserted there is no study of phenomena without studying it in relation to the self. Both philosophers believed we are thrown into the world against our will, and Ortega insisted this is why we philosophize, to learn about the realm we were thrust into. Both stressed the idea of authenticity and being true to self, whatever that means for the individual. Ortega maintained each of us is responsible for his own survival and giving his life shape, but those characteristics are revealed in how we play the game of life, interacting with other people and objects.
- (There were four good lectures on Camus that went into his short stories at length along with one mostly focused on the Myth of Sisyphus, but I ended up going to Gemini to summarize the absurd using Myth of Sisyphus as an example since I didn't take good notes while working out, since it's my favorite concept out of Existentialism.)
- Albert Camus defined the Absurd as the fundamental conflict between humanity's innate desire for inherent meaning, purpose, and clarity, and the cold, silent, and indifferent universe that refuses to provide it. It is not the world itself that is absurd, but the inescapable clash between our minds and reality.
- In his 1942 essay The Myth of Sisyphus, Camus uses Greek mythology to illustrate this concept:
    - The Absurd Condition: Sisyphus is condemned by the gods to endlessly roll a massive boulder up a mountain, only to watch it roll back down to the bottom for eternity.

Camus uses this as the ultimate metaphor for the human condition: waking up, going to work, eating, sleeping, and repeating the cycle, a life largely composed of repetitive, often futile tasks in pursuit of no lasting objective.
    - The Moment of Consciousness: The absurdity truly takes hold on Sisyphus's walk back down the mountain to retrieve the rock. In this moment, he is fully lucid and conscious of his fate. He recognizes the utter pointlessness of his task, yet he chooses to keep walking down and pushing the rock anyway.
    - The Absurd Revolt: Camus argues that instead of succumbing to despair or seeking false hope (like religion or suicide), one should live in a state of open-eyed revolt. By fiercely embracing his meaningless, relentless task with full awareness, Sisyphus strips the gods of their power to punish him.
    - The Conclusion: Camus famously concludes: "One must imagine Sisyphus happy." Joy is found not in achieving a final, transcendent goal, but in the fierce, passionate struggle of living itself.
- (Back to the lectures.) While Myth of Sisyphus's focus is on solitary rebellion, The Plague focuses on shared rebellion in the direction of solidarity and participation, especially in the literal reading of the plague being a disease. The Plague can be read on several levels and Camus believes it to be his most anti-Christian work. Camus thought hoping for something better in the afterlife didn't justify giving up on making this life less hellish. Camus also disagreed with the Christian view that people are to blame for phenomena like plagues. The plague is also a meditation on fascism and a chronicle of the resistance. One problem with looking at the plague as a metaphor for fascism is the fact that fascism has its roots in humans. Unlike the plague, which is a natural force where our struggles are in vain and our powerlessness absurd, fascism was caused by people and was defeated by people.
- Like Hegel, Sartre believed we only become a self in relation to others. Sartre is known for the gloomy conclusion "Hell is other people." But he believed loneliness was a worse fate than being with others.
- You are more than your vocation, and it is "bad faith" to focus entirely on your role and forget it's your free choice every morning to assume the role and there are other dimensions to your existence. "I am..." "A Senior Software Engineer", "a father", "a good man." No matter how many of these attributes you list, you are missing something essential to what it means to be me. Even the strictest profession leaves room for self-expression. Instead of a good waiter, you can choose to be good and playful. We should also respect others' choice of self-expression and not treat them as an object. Sartre believed we chose what we become but at the same time are bound to make a choice in line with the facts of, or historicity of, our situation. You become what you are in the context of what others have made of you. Sartre thought it "bad faith" to do nothing to change your situation but also

"bad faith" to ignore the limits around you. You have to be aware of the price you pay for change. There is definite tension between freedom and the facts of our lives.

- One of Beauvoir's most important philosophical messages is that freedom without responsibility is meaningless. Being unattached to commitments stifles action, and we are as responsible for doing nothing as doing something. Doing nothing means we are nothing. Only by committing ourselves and engaging in the world with vitality and love can we create an authentic and meaningful life.